

THE MAGIC OF VFX

One of the most high-profile productions about to exploit the potential of a good visual effects budget is two-part *Ramayana*, directed by Nitesh Tiwari and starring Ranbir Kapoor, Yash, Sunny Deol and Sai Pallavi, slated to release next year and already expected to be the most expensive Indian film to date with an estimated budget of Rs 4,000 crore. International collaborators in the art and action departments have been roped in, along with Oscar-winning composer Hans Zimmer to complement A.R. Rahman. "The idea is to take the film beyond India to the world," said producer Namit Malhotra, also the CEO of the Oscar-winning visual effects studio DNEG working on the film. Malhotra wants to "push the needle" when it comes to the film's imagery and two years will be devoted to post-production alone.

It's not just technical wizardry that guarantees success in the myth genre, though. *Mahavatar Narsimha*'s animation is no match for the quality of international giants like Pixar, Dreamworks and Studio Ghibli, but it was the strength of its emotions that resonated with audiences. "If it lands, it doesn't matter what the animation is like. You need to be relevant and authentic in terms of the story," says Andhare. What also helps is that it has the "grammar of a classic South Indian masala film", even getting into gruesomely violent territory at times, doffing its hat to the visual legacy left behind by Amar Chitra Katha comics rather than Hollywood superhero films. "We have reduced our own relevance to the entire country by shrinking our stories and gaze to only looking outward. We are a ritualistic, faith-based and *bhakti*-oriented society. This is us," says Andhare. "We don't need to be like a graphic novel or imitate the colour and syntax of a western film."

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> **Producer, *Mahavatar Narsimha***



Mahavatar Narsimha director Kumar agrees. "Producers need to understand that animation is a powerful medium," he told INDIA TODAY DIGITAL. "Hollywood, China, Japan, and Korea have shown this for years, often with animated films outperforming live action. In India, sadly, that hasn't been the case until now. I hope this film inspires producers to treat animation as seriously as live-action... Your only limitation [there] is your imagination." Producer Vijay Kiragandur, of Hombale Films, adds, "We have the best animation production studios in the world. All we needed was to present Indian stories using these technical superiorities." And with the sequel, *Mahavatar Parshuram*, already set for a 2027 release, the industry may be gearing up for many more such stories to come. ■



ANGELS AND DEMONS Vishnu's avatar in *Mahavatar Narsimha;* (Above) Poster of Netflix's *Kurukshetra*